

Clayton Glazier

04/27/26

LIS 501

Myth busting #6

“If it’s on my computer screen, it must be legitimate.”

A lot of people think anything a computer shows must be trustworthy, pop-ups, alerts, login screens, you name it. Bruce Schneier talks about this in *Secrets and Lies*, pointing out that most people don’t really know what’s happening behind the scenes. They just assume computers work like reliable machines, handing out accurate info and keeping them safe. So, when something pops up, people rarely stop to question whether it’s real or even where it’s coming from.

This isn’t surprising. In everyday life, if you flip a light switch, the light comes on. Press a button, something happens. That predictability makes people carry the same mindset over to computers. They figure every response is legit, a direct result of what they just did. But computers aren’t that simple. They’ll show you whatever they’re told to, and sometimes, malicious stuff sneaks in through the cracks.

This blind trust is exactly what attackers bank on. Plenty of cyber threats aren’t all that technical, they just dress up as trusted messages. Fake security warnings, bogus software updates, and those sketchy phishing emails look so convincing that people fall for them without a second thought. Hackers aren’t busting down digital doors, they’re just playing into your willingness to believe what’s on the screen.

Take Nathan, for example. He’s working away on his laptop when a window pops up saying, “Your bank information is outdated. Click this link and login to update.” Looks legit, so he clicks it. Turns out, that message wasn’t from his system but from malware that slipped in after he’d visited a dodgy website to stream a sports game. By clicking, Nathan accidentally gave a hacker remote access to his laptop. He thought he was just following a routine instruction; instead, he opened the door to a serious security mess.

This kind of thinking causes real trouble. People get used to trusting anything with a familiar logo or official-sounding words. They click links, punch in passwords, and download files, all because their computer “asked” them to. Schneier points out that people are pretty good at spotting physical dangers, you’ll notice a broken fence or smell smoke. But digital threats? Not so much. That’s why social engineering works so well: attackers just trick you into letting them in.

Computers aren’t naturally trustworthy. They’re just machines running whatever someone told them to run, good or bad. What you see on your screen isn’t automatically true or safe. For security, you’ve got to rely on your own judgment. So, don’t accept everything at face value. Pause, check the source, look at URLs closely, and treat unexpected messages with caution. A computer’s output isn’t gospel, it’s just info that needs a closer look before you act.